Americas and then to Moscow, ‘an extraordinary world of stowaways, false identities, secret codes, cheap firearms, assassinations and conspiracies’[5] emerged, as Prof. Tim Harper’s magnificent new book makes clear. The point is, Bhagat Singh was not apart from this furtive world. From false identities to conspiracies to assassinations, he indulged in all these in order to bring down the Empire in India. Quite contrary to the traditional accounts of that such as Dr Pattabhi Sitaramayya, whose official history of the Congress Party we are all familiar with, it is this history from below that needs to be understood now if an accurate and realistic story of Independence is to be told. Second, and not unrelated to this, it is time to acknowledge how changes in our history, brought about by transformative radical movements, have failed to recognize the role played by the anarchist. This is a problem not just in India but in Europe as well. John Quail, in his lost history of British anarchists[6], has explained how the British anarchist movement developed between the years of 1880 to 1930 but has today been largely obscured. He argues for the resurrection of the vibrant stories of these unsung heroes, tumultuous political activities and searing manifestos. Of course, the last ten years of the period that John Quail sets out was also the period of Bhagat Singh’s blistering manifestoes, radical dissent and withering denunciation of the Raj. For John Quail, the story of British anarchism is still being written today. For India, it has not even begun. Even the great historical works on India by such British stalwarts as Percival Spear[7], C.H. Philips[8] and Judith Brown[9] are silent about Bhagat Singh.

Returning to the increasingly fashionable practice of seeking apologies, what we can say from the perspective presented above is that the practically useful step would be to have changes in school curricula, the teaching of history from below, the mainstreaming of the revolutionary freedom struggle in our narratives and recognition of the role of the anarchist. The potential of such accounts for connecting with and confronting current ideologies of racism, xenophobia and the intolerance of minorities will otherwise go unappreciated. As it is, ‘[b]oth Congress and Sangh Parivar vigorously attempt to deny Bhagat Singh’s revolutionary ideology and